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Leslie Gourse

Leslie Gourse is a freelance writer, contributing regularly to such periodicals as Down Beat, Jazz Times, Newsday, *the* New York Times *and many others. Her study of jazz singers and their craft,* Louis' Children *received much critical acclaim. Leslie also penned a full length biography of Joe Williams, entitled* Every Day, The Story of Joe Williams. *Her novel,* With Gall and Honey, *won the Doubleday-Columbia University fiction award. She lives in New York City.*

Leslie was interviewed in New York City on March 9, 1996 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a real pleasure to have with us Leslie Gourse, author, and jazz expert I can say because I've been listening to you earlier today talk with Joe Williams and I think you know your material pretty well.

LG: Well he's one of the people that's responsible for my knowing it. He was so helpful when I was doing this book. Of course he experienced just about the whole history of jazz himself first hand, and he knew everyone to tell me who to listen to and who he'd worked with and it's just a lesson in jazz history just to know about his life.

MR: Now you've written for magazines and a couple of well known books, *Louis' Children* and of course the book about Joe which we'll talk about more, but what brought you into the field of jazz?

LG: Well I always listened to jazz, you know, as a teenager and in high school in Providence, Rhode Island, I used to go to a place called the Celebrity Club when I was under age and shouldn't have been there. And then when I came to New York I just gravitated towards listening to it. I heard Symphony Sid on the radio every night from midnight to five AM, and I used to go to the jazz clubs. And why I liked jazz more than any other music I don't know. I did like other music too. I liked pop, I liked rock & roll, I liked rhythm & blues. But I did love jazz.

MR: There's something about seeing it live, you know, in a club, where it's so spontaneous and you kind of catch that moment. It's really fascinating.

LG: Sometimes it's just the greatest experience. To see Joe work live is always a great time. And to see people like Carmen McRae and to hear them live, it was so exciting, to hear her in Birdland sing "Skyliner." It was just a real experience that you can't describe.

MR: Well you know you that was just kind of reading my mind, in describing — when you have to describe a musical performance, I would think it's difficult and I have to compliment you on your various ways you describe people singing — you were talking about Jon Hendricks and different singers. It's hard to put it into words sometimes, but you made me want to go listen to the records—

LG: Right.

MR: —so that I could hear it again.

LG: Yes. A girlfriend last night, Joanne Brackeen plays piano and told me she heard a singer on the radio, Kevin Mahogany, and she had never heard him before but from the way that he was singing and the way I had described him to her, she knew who it was. So that's wonderful. I do have that ability, to tell people what it sounds like, to bridge the gap. I'm not a musicologist, and I do not try to be nor want to be. I just don't. But I do want people to have the feeling that they know something of what's going on musically, and why they like it and what they're hearing, and who the people are and how it expresses them as a person, and how the music generally reflects the best of that person's character or personality.

MR: Do you feel that you have to be part detective when you write these books?

LG: Probably.

MR: I always wonder how you find out some of these facts.

LG: I have a background of being a journalist and being an investigative reporter. I have the knack and talent for that. I was a stringer for the National Desk at the *Times*, and I remember being asked to investigate twenty people or so who were on the House Committee to investigate Watergate. Twenty young lawyers. I had to find out in three or four days who the lawyers were, and find out all about their backgrounds. And I did it. And the National Desk of the *Times* and the head of the Desk in Washington was astounded that I had done it — like staying on the phone for four days straight without sleeping I guess — but I had done it. And I had done more than anyone else in the country because New York had the most people.

MR: Can you define "stringer" for me?

LG: I was hired to do general assignment reporting, social trends, general assignment reporting, by the National Desk on a regular basis and I did it for four years, and I had a card, a telephone card, and I had a regular little stipend, and it was not—I did the same work as a regular reporter, but I was not in the union. And there was a reason for that, because they wanted the City Desk reporters to do the job that I was doing, but the National Desk wanted their own person right in New York. And so they had me. They had me, but they couldn't get me into the union. I had been in the union before, doing another job at the *Times* for three years. And I left that to take the contract with the National Desk.

MR: I guess along the way the contacts that you pick up and the impressions that you make on them are pretty important later on when you go back and these people know your name, and they're more willing to talk to you?

LG: Musicians? They were so nice from the start, and Joe was one of the nicest. Most musicians are so cooperative and so intuitive and so candid, it's rare, very rare that you'll find a musician who was not helpful or who was not able to be for one reason or another, perhaps he wasn't well — there were a couple, maybe two or three who were not really able to do it. But most of them were the loveliest people to interview and to talk to. Charm may be part of their business. Maybe that's why — they're so charming with the public. But they are really lovely with me. They were great with me.

MR: I was interested in the whole premise behind *Louis' Children*. Because we read an awful lot about Louis Armstrong's tremendous influence, almost creation of jazz as a whole. But not as many people talk about his influence from a vocal aspect. Most people are talking about the way he played trumpet and his improvised solos. What made you choose that particular subject?

LG: Singers?

MR: Yeah.

LG: I'm very sensitive to the singers. I generally can recognize any voice, anyone singing I can recognize. I can recognize if it's Doris Day, or Joe or of course Mel Torme, any of them. They are very distinctive. I have an easier time of recognizing them then I might say the trumpet players. I can distinguish Miles Davis in a minute. But there are some trumpet players that I don't hear clearly. I can't say oh that's definitely so-and-so. Some people can, they're very sensitive to the horn players. So I mean I hear pianists and a lot of them sound alike to me. I mean I can tell Art Tatum from John Hicks or from Tommy Flanagan, but every singer just about I get correctly.

MR: So many of the veteran musicians we've talked to have stated how important it was back in the 30s and 40s that you establish your own sound. And that's kind of what they were talking about. They wanted people to be able to recognize them after a few bars. Of course you could recognize Lester Young versus Coleman Hawkins I guess, but for an instrumentalist it's a little harder than the vocalist I guess.

LG: It depends on your ears. For me I find the vocalists much easier. There are people who as I say just immediately know who the horn player is or who the pianist is.

MR: Now this could be a hard question, but do you have a definition for a jazz vocalist?

LG: No. I mean there are things and characteristics of jazz vocalists. They improvise, that's number one. I think that might be the most important distinction. The way they phrase, the way the tell a story, you know any good singer has to be in tune, they have to tell a story well. I think the improvisation and the way they improvise and the phrasing and the feeling distinguishes a jazz vocalist or jazz influenced pop vocalists.

MR: Some people don't like to be put in categories anyway. They would rather be just called singers.

LG: Yeah.

MR: Now Joe has had this — during his career he's had this blues thing. And sometimes, from what I've read, it was a little too pervasive and he wanted to be an all-around singer. And he almost got typecast.

LG: Joe was a ballad singer to start. And then he liked some of the blues things and he started to use them on the South Side of Chicago. And he used the Memphis Slim song, "Every Day." And Memphis Slim used to like to go hear him sing it, but Memphis said to me personally, when I interviewed him about Joe, he said, "Joe's a pop singer." You know? And he was. He was a balladeer and he sang the ballads mostly and that's what he wanted to be known as. And Hank Jones the pianist bumped into him in the midwest before Joe went with Basie and always thought that Joe was a balladeer. When Joe went with Basie, Basie had a blues-based band, and he stayed with that. So Joe had to fit in. So Joe had to sing a lot of blues. And he could do it, but he was not a really rough blues singer. He has a certain urbanity and a polish and he can do anything, I mean he's a brilliant performer, and so talented that he can sing anything. But he did blues secondarily. His first thing was really to be a pop — he even sang opera a little bit on the South end of Chicago, I forget which opera he did but he did at least one of them.

MR: Chicago was such a fertile city for music.

LG: And particularly the blues. He did hear it there when he was growing up.

MR: A couple of the musicians from that time have expressed that there were certain parts of Chicago too that, they loved the blues, but they almost distinguished between the real, southern, guitar oriented blues as opposed to the way like Basie and the way they used the blues.

LG: Yeah. Well Basie had a very sophisticated approach to the blues. He was a sophisticated musician and he played for dancing, and he certainly did not want any blues singer who was also going to play guitar or maybe garble the words, no. He wanted someone who was going to connect and really communicate to everyone. He wanted an international band, and that's what he put together.

MR: What are you working on these days? When you came in I asked you what are you working on and you said, "Oh boy I've got many deadlines."

LG: Oh, right. Well I'm doing a couple of stories, one for the *Los Angeles Times* on the jazz club scene in New York now. I'm going to do something on Paris for American Airlines, on the drinking habits of the French.

MR: Do you get to go to Paris in the —

LG: I go, yeah, I go pretty often on a holiday. And then I'm doing a couple of other stories. But then I've done four books in a series on jazz history by instrument — by singers, pianists, bassists and horn players are done. Now I have to do guitarists and drummers.

And that's for a company called Franklin Watts. I have three biographies out on Aretha Franklin, Billie Holiday and Mahalia Jackson is just coming out, also with Franklin Watts. And I had a book out on Dizzy Gillespie and the birth of bebop for kids, and by kids I mean teenagers. And now facing me I have this as I said the drum book and the guitar book, and I just did an anthology and I'm finishing up the details on writings about Billie Holiday by other writers. I did the introduction and I'm going to do one on Ella Fitzgerald, that's for Schirmer Books, and I'm doing, they've asked me to do a biography of Thelonious Monk. That's a major, major project.

MR: That would be major, yes.

LG: Yeah. Especially since so many people are dead who knew him and knew him well. So it's a major challenge in a lot of ways. I think he was a grouch. I keep that in mind, I've got a certain theme in mind.

MR: We've heard some interesting stories about him, connected with the "Great Day in Harlem" and what it took to get him to that session I guess.

LG: No, I didn't hear anything—

MR: Well it's in the film.

LG: It's in the "Great Day in Harlem?"

MR: Yes. He spent hours like deciding what to wear and finally picked on something that he knew would stand out from everybody else, and etcetera, etcetera.

LG: Yeah, he was aware of how good he was and he was a little grouchy that people weren't as aware as he was as early as he was aware.

MR: Now do the publishers request that you write these? How does that work? I mean you seem to have quite a good resume here.

LG: Well I did do a little proposal for a book on Monk, and just in conversation with the Schirmer Books editor, someone told me to call, he needed some anthologies. So I did. And he asked me what I did, he said, "What are you working on now?" And I said well I'm doing this and that. And he said, "Gee I'd like you to do a biography for us sometime." I said, "Well, I have a couple of proposals." One was on Carmen McRae and one was on Monk and one was on Ella. And he said, "Oh, I'd like the one on Monk, you can send that along to me." "Really?" I said, "All right." So I put it in the mail. And he called me up and he said, "Well we're going to do that." So that's how that one happened. I think with the biographies of Billie and Aretha and Mahalia, I was told what to do because I would not have picked Mahalia or Aretha, because they're not jazz people. I mean they're related, the music is related to jazz, but I was told that that's what they wanted.

MR: You have some nice quotes about — returning to Joe for a moment — did you find him an easy interview?

LG: I was just going to say that. He was the most forthcoming guy. And he is brilliant. And he's a hard worker, and he loves to work, and it was something different then, you know, to do this book. Well you can see for years he'd never sat down to do a book. So he sat down with me with tapes, and we spoke on the phone after I would work on something I might read it to him on the phone, and then a couple of times we met face to face and I read to him and we went over it. And I could read, you know because we had limited time, if I only had him for a day I would have to read really fast. He could really hear it fast, and really know what to do. He was great.

MR: I guess that comes from his profession. His profession is he's a professional listener.

LG: Almost he is — of working with words. Definitely he could have done a book himself. But he would not because he's always busy traveling, singing, and it takes up a lot of energy, then he goes home and he'd better do something to stay healthy, to go on the golf course or just to have a good time and relax. That takes a lot of energy to get on those bandstands and sing for two sets a night, or three as it used to be sometimes.

MR: Did you get to know Jillean somewhat?

LG: Yes. I went out to their house, I met her, and the thing that struck me was her eyes. You know she was not the young, beautiful kid. As I mentioned she was a mature woman but beautiful in a new way. Her eyes were so full of light, and I could see why Joe was charmed forever about Jillean. We're all getting a little older, but she is just a charming woman. Beautiful eyes and just a lovely, lovely woman. A lovely woman. Kind.

MR: I've been struck by the dignity that many of these veteran African-American musicians carry with them, and when you hear about — in fact they're not that forthcoming with some of the stories about traveling in the south and so forth, but when you do hear some of them they weathered it so well. It seems like they don't have a lot of negative, they refuse to be negative or carry that with them — I think — for the most part.

LG: Well I think it's just part of not letting life in general, the negative take over. Sometimes to keep themselves sane they made up funny stories that happened to them. Sometimes they would tell stories that were very, very touching and from just one incident you get the feeling of the whole mess. And some people just wouldn't even go south after a while, they just said, "Oh, please!" They had some bad experiences in the north too. But they tend not to dwell on it, but they are definitely affected by the history. Having met them now, from the '60s, '70s can really not comprehend what it was like for them. It would once have been impossible for me to have met them and interviewed them — if indeed anyone wanted to read about them in kind of a real way. So it's hard. You have to put yourself — and that was not all that long ago you know. And so some of these people do have a definite prejudice against the former oppressors.

MR: So when you go to approach a book, okay now I'm going to write about guitarists, how do you start something like that? Do you start doing your own research and look into what's available to listen to, or do you visit an archive?

LG: Well, yeah, I'm going to do all that. But I know I'm going to begin with Charlie Christian, and I'm going to go from Charlie Christian on to Wes Montgomery, and there are others, Eddie Lang and Oscar Moore in the older crowd. So I mean by now there's a certain amount I've picked up enough to know who were the major influences, who were the major stylists, and who I'll concentrate on and who comes from them and who listened to them. And then on to George Benson. And so I have some ideas. But I'm going to go and look at the books that have already been written for adults, and I'm going to go back and listen to a lot of music, and I'm going to go and try to see what I can find about among the New Orleans guitarists, because I'm not aware of any really, and I'm sure there are some — oh of course, what am I talking about — Danny Barker the banjo player, but he was a banjo player. But maybe that's where, you know I have to go back to the roots and find out about the roots of jazz guitar, because I guess it's — yeah, what's his name, cousin Joseph, cousin Joe. I think he started on guitar and then he had to play piano one night when his piano player didn't show up and so he went over to playing the piano, but he plays guitar. I guess those early blues players all did.

MR: So many people that we've talked to have always mentioned Freddie Green too. Even though he wasn't a major soloist, he set the —

LG: But he's later on. I'm talking about before. I'll go to Freddie Green, that was a big name. And he gave Basie's rhythm section a special sound. Very important. But I'm going to go back to the roots and see who were the first. Because all of the blues players played guitar. That's where that came from.

MR: Joe has a fine group right now of musicians he usually works with, which includes a young guitarist that — let's see his piano player is Norman Simmons, and let's see if I can remember the guitar player.

LG: It's not Howard Alden right now is it?

MR: What's that?

LG: Is it Howard Alden?

MR: No, it's not Howard Alden. And since I brought it up I should be able to remember the name. I'll remember it in a moment. But he depends a lot – I'm sorry I can't remember.

LG: Joe plays guitar himself.

MR: He does?

LG: Yeah, a little bit. At least a little bit. I don't know how much. You know writing this whole book he never mentioned to me he played guitar.

MR: No kidding?

LG: Isn't that funny?

MR: I really enjoyed listening to his description about what he got from his family and his grandmother and so forth, what kind of character they seemed to instill in him.

LG: His grandmother was a big influence on him. She's the one who took him by the hand and brought him on the train up to Chicago. His mother went first and brought her sister, and then brought her mother and Joe. So I think his grandmother was a major influence on him.

MR: Same with Milt Hinton. He said almost the same scenario. Because they came up to Chicago in small numbers so that they would send money home and the rest of them could come.

LG: Did Milt Hinton's grandmother bring him up? Or was it his mother?

MR: I think it was his mother, yeah.

LG: Milt had a difficult relationship with his mother. It was different. Of course she exerted a great influence on him too, she was a music teacher. But she was always disappointed in him she wanted him to play piano, he wanted to play violin, and so she always told him, "Why can't you be more like Nat Cole?" He couldn't stand that. Nathaniel. "Why can't you be more like Nathaniel?" But Joe didn't have that difficulty with his mother, not at all. But yes, they all came from the south and those who succeeded did have a lot of encouragement and it wasn't overt encouragement. They didn't realize it was encouragement, but it was just an emphasis on music and on culture and on things. To improve yourself and to have a vision to make sure that you did something with your life.

MR: Well speaking about, "Why can't you be like Nat Cole," I read a few things about when Joe had to replace, when Joe became Basie's singer, he had to follow Jimmy Rushing, and apparently there was some problems with that I guess, maybe over in England or something.

LG: Yes, there were. Well they wanted the same old thing. They loved Rushing and Rushing was a real blues singer, and he had a higher, plaintive voice. And Joe was not the same type of blues singer. He was more polished as a singer. And he had a different gift. And in England they love trad jazz, traditional jazz. And in France too, they had a lot of clubs, and they still have any number of people who only like traditional jazz, trad jazz, early jazz. They still haven't gotten anywhere near bebop. I don't even know how far they're into the Swing Era they are. Yeah. It's beautiful music. There's nothing wrong with it. But it is definitely a period. And people like that.

MR: How has the jazz scene changed in New York?

LG: Lately?

MR: Lately.

LG: Well you know into the 1970s there was a club called Slugs on the Lower East Side and I think it billed itself as Slugs and the Far East. And it was out of the way and it was a dive. The music was beautiful but it was physically a dive. Somehow in the late 1970s jazz started to undergo a renaissance in the appreciation of the public. And clubs opened and sometimes clubs closed but many clubs have survived and they are elegant and they have good food and it's no longer a music that you listen to in a grungy club. You go to the best places and you hear music in the best places. You go to Barney's, you go to the other store, not Calvin Klein but the other famous men's store. They pipe music in, it's always Billie Holiday and Louis Armstrong, I mean jazz is getting the respect that it always has been due. And it's an art music. It's funded by the NEA. I mean it gets cut up and down but still it started to become funded in 1968. So it has become a part of the Lincoln Center. The whole atmosphere for jazz is more welcoming. I mean the first jazz film score was Duke Ellington and it was "Anatomy of a Murder" as I recall.

MR: Sounds right.

LG: And that was in the 50s. Well France used bebop for a film score before that. So we're a little bit Johnny Come Lately, but then as the schools took jazz in to teach, that helped legitimize it and call people's attention to the art. So it's reflected in the clubs. It's reflected in the seriousness of the kids who play. It's reflected in the degree of care that the musicians generally give themselves and the music now. They don't — it's not to wing it. They study, they practice, they really—

MR: They've done their homework.

LG: Yeah. They have to. You can't not go to school and play jazz now. You have to study.

MR: It's interesting you say that. Because I guess there's not the training ground available that there was for some of these people.

LG: Well then when you think of what they did in the 30s, 40s and 50s without schools, and you think of what they did and now you think how could they have ever done that great music without training. Well they had private lessons and they had each other. I don't know how they did it though. It was a miracle that they could invent this music.

MR: Right.

LG: Yeah. So how could they invent it even with school? You know?

MR: Maybe they did well — maybe it was better that they didn't have it I don't know.

LG: So they said.

MR: But it is a fact that most of them are getting their training in school now and then kind of competing for the jobs.

LG: They have to study now.

MR: Was there experiences that you had in middle or high school that led you to being a writer and would you have any advice for aspiring writers these days?

LG: I knew in my teens that I wanted to be a writer, early in my teens, and I wrote poetry to express whatever was going on in my mind, certain cares I had. And I excelled in that. I was good at it. And I went to college. I started as a playwriting major. I wanted to major in writing, but there were no courses really. I think that Columbia University and maybe Stanford on the west coast — is it Stanford? — no—

MR: I don't know.

LG: Well it's a big school out there, I think it's Stanford University, and there was a school in the Midwest, either Earlham or Morrison. There were very few schools that would let you major in writing when I started college which was 1956. So I went into the School of Dramatic Arts as a playwriting major at Columbia at the age of 17, and you know I didn't know how to write. I was good at dialogue although it didn't really show up at that time. And I switched into the school of general studies during the semester I was twenty, I turned twenty. I'd already been studying and I already knew that's what I was going to go into, prose, and I wrote a novel. And from there I took one journalism course and didn't get much out of that, but when I got out of school I wanted to go into non-fiction. Because that was the time when people were turning away from fiction to non-fiction. That's when I think around that time Truman Capote wrote his non-fiction novel, or he was going to write it. It was in the air that non-fiction was going to reign and going to become regarded as high art. And I wanted — people wanted to deal with what was real, rather than — and it was hard to write fiction too, so I thought it was easier to write non-fiction, and it is, for me. So that's how it happened. But I always knew — my father collected books, and my mother was always quoting Shakespeare. And we had good music in the house. We had jazz, we had classical, we had everything, so I had a good background in the arts and I was really led that way, influenced that was to become an artistic type. I could paint. If I weren't a writer I'd probably be a portrait painter.

MR: Well it was a good match then to put together your love of writing with your love of jazz and you've got quite a nice list of things you've done.

LG: Yes I've done a lot. As I look back I say really, that's a lot. I'm going to write another novel and maybe some screenplays. I'd like to do some screenplays.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking to you.

LG: Well thanks a lot. How do you love jazz? How did you come to love jazz?

MR: Whoa — I'm being interviewed all of a sudden. That's great. That's a good question. I think it came from my parents. They used to play Glenn Miller records. And that caught my ear and I started out on the clarinet and then switched to saxophone. And there was a few moments along in my life, first of all hearing the Glenn Miller orchestra, although Glenn wasn't there, but and then hearing Paul Desmond with the Brubeck Quartet on the radio, and then later hearing Cannonball Adderley. Those things made big impressions on

me and that was really the start of it. Interviewing folks like yourself and all the musicians has been really informative for me and for the college here. Because we hope that all our students and visitors to the college will be using this as a way to learn about the history of the music. So thanks for your time.

LG: My pleasure.

MR: Thanks for meeting with Joe this morning.

LG: My pleasure. It was my pleasure to do that interview. He's so good.

MR: He is.

LG: Do you believe that he's over 50 years old? He doesn't look it. Does he?

MR: No. He's great. So on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank Leslie Gourse, and hope to be reading your next publication soon.

LG: Well I hope so. Thanks a lot.